The Fear Ladder — Teacher Guide



TEACHER GUIDE · READ ONCE

1 Who it's for

LEVEL	B1–B2
FOR	Individuals or small groups
LENGTH	Modular — any one Part is a mini-lesson; the whole pack is two long lessons
STUDENTS WILL LEARN	scared / afraid / frightened / terrified (a person feels it) vs scary / frightening (a thing causes it); luck and superstition words; Halloween customs; mystery and court words (search, explain, trial, guilty, evidence); rephrasing a sentence with a key word.
AFTER THIS PACK, STUDENTS CAN	After this pack, students can tell the scariest thing that happened to them using at least four fear ladder words, and retell a spooky story in their own words.
IN THE PACK	Teacher Book · Student Book · Printables (13 pages) · audio (5 files) · 1 pictures

2 Red lines

1. Listen first. Do not pre-teach the words.
2. Retell before you drill.
3. Model the "Say it again" item 0 yourself, every Part.

3 The course at a glance

STAGE	WHAT HAPPENS	PRINTABLES	STUDENT BOOK
LESSON 1 · The warm class			
1.1 Scariest thing and the first rungs	Say the scariest thing cold, then learn scared vs scary and the "Say it again" task.	p.1 Picture cards, p.2 Fear Ladder strip	p.2
1.2 Lucky or unlucky?	Four superstitions from the USA and Britain, then the words to talk about luck.	p.3 Retell cards, Part 1	p.3
1.3 Where does Halloween come from?	Two ideas about the origin of Halloween, and three modern customs.	p.4 Retell cards, Part 2	p.4
LESSON 2 · The horror class			
2.1 Three horror films	Three horror films and the real things behind them.	p.5 Retell cards, Part 3	p.6
2.2 The mountain mystery	A true unsolved mystery: what happened, what was strange, what the experts say.	p.6 Retell cards, Part 4	p.7
2.3 The devil made me do it	Bonus: a real court case about "possession" — what the judge decided and why.	p.7 Retell cards, Part 5	p.9

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STAGE	WHAT HAPPENS	PRINTABLES	STUDENT BOOK
2.4 Closing the ladder	Rank the fear words, play Taboo, talk, then say your scariest thing again.	p.8–10 Sort cards, p.11–13 Taboo cards	p.10

4 How to read the Teacher Book

1.1 BANNER	Where you are. Each stage starts on a new page.
DO	What you do, step by step. Big and first on every activity.
SAY	The exact words to say, in large type.
BOARD	Write this up before you start.
GOAL	What the activity is for.
GRAMMAR	The deeper explanation, right where you need it.
WATCH OUT	The typical mistake and why Czech learners make it.
IF IT FLOPS	Quick rescue for silence or confusion.
IN THE STUDENT BOOK	The dashed frame is exactly what students see, with the page number.
👉 *Did your opinion change?*	An optional personal follow-up question.
ANSWERS	Under each exercise — scroll down to reveal when screen-sharing.

5 Background

Part 1 — Black cat: bad luck in the US, often good luck in the UK. The origins of the mirror, ladder and knock-on-wood superstitions are theories — say "people say". None of the four is uniquely American. Added facts: in England, Scotland and Ireland the usual phrase is "touch wood"; the ladder-triangle (ancient Egypt) is a theory, not a fact; none of the four is uniquely American. Part 2 — There are two competing theories of where Halloween comes from (Samhain; the Christian All Hallows' Eve). Never present Samhain as proven. Souling is only suggested as the origin of trick-or-treat; Stingy Jack is a folktale. Added facts: Halloween begins Allhallowtide (31 Oct–2 Nov); "trick or treat" is first in print in 1917 (a Canadian newspaper); Stingy Jack is a folktale, told as a story. Part 3 — Michael Myers' mask was a Captain Kirk mask painted white. Carpenter found a young patient's stare in a Kentucky hospital creepy: do not link it to any diagnosis. Craven's sources: an old man at a window, a bully called Fred Krueger, and news of refugees who died in their sleep (many cases later linked to heart conditions, some unexplained). No real event is documented behind Friday the 13th; never give away the killer. Added facts: a 2011 autopsy study linked about 79 % of the sleep-death cases to a heart condition (about 21 % unexplained); the Thirteen Club first met on Friday 13 January 1881 in New York to prove the superstition false. Part 4 — Ten hikers set out in January 1959, Yuri turned back, nine died. The tent was cut open from the inside. The 2020 official avalanche conclusion and the 2021 study explain only some of the injuries. Graphic details and UFO theories are left out on purpose; real young people died. Added facts: Yuri Yudin was the only survivor; the footprints disappeared under snow after about 500 m; the 2021 study (Gaume and Puzrin, Switzerland) explains only some injuries, and Gaume said: "We don't want to pretend that we have solved it." Part 5 — The judge refused the possession defence for lack of evidence, so the jury never heard it; the verdict was manslaughter, 10 to 20 years. The court did not accept possession and gave no lighter sentence for it. The Warrens' account is disputed. Added facts: verdict 24 November 1981, sentence 18 December 1981. Content note: Parts 3–5 mention real deaths, with no graphic detail. If a student is upset, stop and offer to skip the Part; every Part stands alone.

Sources: Wikipedia (Halloween; Friday the 13th; Michael Myers; A Nightmare on Elm Street; Sudden unexpected nocturnal death syndrome; Dyatlov Pass incident; Trial of Arne Cheyenne Johnson; Black cat; Knocking on wood), Britannica, Live Science, History.com, Boston.com, The Hartford, Den of Geek. Full list with links: spec §16.

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6 Correction

> Do not correct mid-story. During the retell, note three points only — one grammar, one vocabulary, one pronunciation — then say each back correctly and have the student repeat it.

7 Before you start

- The audio files for each Part (see What's in the pack).
- Scissors, for the cards.
- Optional, only for the trailer task in 2.4: internet and a speaker.
- Print and cut: Picture cards — Printables p.1, for stage 1.1
- Print and cut: Fear Ladder strip — Printables p.2, for stage 1.1
- Print and cut: Retell cards, Part 1 — Printables p.3, for stage 1.2
- Print and cut: Retell cards, Part 2 — Printables p.4, for stage 1.3
- Print and cut: Retell cards, Part 3 — Printables p.5, for stage 2.1
- Print and cut: Retell cards, Part 4 — Printables p.6, for stage 2.2
- Print and cut: Retell cards, Part 5 — Printables p.7, for stage 2.3
- Print and cut: Sort cards — Printables p.8–10, for stage 2.4
- Print and cut: Taboo cards — Printables p.11–13, for stage 2.4

8 Quick start

A gentle warm class: 1.1 (first question only) + 1.2 + 1.3 + the talk in 2.4.

A "horror" class: 1.1 + Part 3 (2.1) + Part 4 (2.2) + the ladder sort and the closing question in 2.4.

The full ladder: everything in order. Speaking only: 1.1 + 2.4.

Easiest to cut or add: 2.3 (bonus) and 1.2 (shortest). Any one Part works alone.

9 Adapting this pack

One audio, two tracks. B1: word bank in the gap-fill, three keywords on each retell card, extra time in "Say it again", talk groups A and B.

B2: cover the word bank and fill the gaps from memory first, fold each retell card to the heading and add an opinion line, ask for a second version in "Say it again", talk groups B and C.

Extra rungs are for everyone who wants them; top-rung words are optional. In Taboo, B1 sees the forbidden words, B2 does not and answers in two sentences.

10 What's in the pack

- The Fear Ladder – Lessons 1–2 – Teacher Book (37 pages)
- The Fear Ladder – Lessons 1–2 – Student Book (19 pages)
- The Fear Ladder – Lessons 1–2 – Printables (13 pages)
- The Fear Ladder – Lessons 1–2 – Teacher Guide (this file)
- Audio, Part 1: P1_superstitions_full.mp3 (segments P1A, P1B)
- Audio, Part 2: P2_halloween_history_full.mp3 (segments P2A, P2B)
- Audio, Part 3: P3_horror_films_full.mp3 (segments P3A, P3B, P3C)
- Audio, Part 4: P4_mountain_mystery_full.mp3 (segments P4A, P4B, P4C, P4D)
- Audio, Part 5: P5_devil_made_me_full.mp3 (segments P5A, P5B)

For use with your own students. Please don't share or resell the files.

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Facts in this lesson were checked against the sources on 16 October 2026. Where sources disagree, the lesson says so. The audio is AI-generated.